The give-away pile rules card

Every cleaning blitz ends at the same question: *can this leave the house yet?* This card is the tiebreaker. Print it twice — glue one inside the file-cabinet door, tape one near wherever you open mail. Content below is identical twice on purpose; cut them apart along the dashed lines.

RULE ONE · THE YEAR QUESTION

Does this page name a tax year?

If a paper whispers a year — W-2s, 1099s, receipts you might claim, statements with a year in the header — it skips the give-away pile entirely and goes to this year's folders (Sheets 1 and 2 show it the way).

RULE TWO · THE SHREDDER LINE

Anything with account numbers shreds first

Pay stubs, old statements, expired cards, pre-approved credit offers: the give-away pile only leaves the house after the shredder (or scissors and a heavy hand) has eaten anything with a number on it. Until then it isn't trash, it's homework.

RULE THREE · THREE-BOX SORTING

Sort once, in three piles

1. Folder: names a tax year, or feeds a deduction — goes to the folders, done. **2. Long keep:** documents that go with objects and decades — home purchase papers, warranties, retirement records. **3. Give away:** everything else — but through rule two first.

RULE FOUR · THE DOUBT CLAUSE

When in doubt, it goes in the folder

Folders are cheap; regret is not. A questionable paper can always leave next year. The tax-time panic pile (that's who this whole kit hugs) never has to see it again either way.

EASILY LET GO (AFTER RULE TWO)

- Pay stubs once the year's W-2 or final statement matches them
- Utility, phone, and internet bills for finished months
- Old insurance ID cards after replacements arrive
- Credit-card and bank statements once the tax year behind them is closed and filed
- Pre-approved credit mailers — shred, always

TO THE FOLDERS INSTEAD

- Anything claiming to be deductible: medical, charity, education
- Receipts for the big-ticket things you own
- Home improvement paperwork
- Anything with this year's name on it that arrived uninvited
- The "I'm not sure" pile — see rule four

LONG KEEPERS

- Filed tax returns themselves — they are more keepable than the receipts behind them
- House purchase, sale, or refinance papers
- Car titles and big purchase records
- Warranty cards for things still actually alive
- The folder labeled **IMPORTANT, NOT URGENT** — deeds, Powers of Attorney, certificates

WARM TIP

The give-away pile is allowed to wait a month before it leaves the house — that's not procrastination, that's a cooling-off period for big decisions. The only rule it can't break: nothing with names, numbers, or accounts goes out in readable form. Defaults here are friendly habits, not legal retention requirements; what you must keep is a question for your own official sources and pros.

This is a paper organizer, never tax, legal, or financial advice.